protection in Pakistan.' He argued, 'There is no other way. So long as there is a Government dealing with a situation [on Hindu minorities], you have to deal through that Government.' For Nehru, as the political historian B.D. Graham summed it up, 'India could not interfere in the internal affairs of another polity, in this case Pakistan, even when the question at issue was the future of Pakistan's Hindu minorities'. For Mookerjee, 'the mere fact that that they were Hindus was sufficient justification for India's taking action'.[24] A Hindu anywhere, in this conception, was India's concern. More so if they were in Pakistan.

These disagreements and Mookerjee's exit from Nehru's government created a deep schism within the Congress. Mookerjee had, as an early historian of the Jan Sangh noted, 'acted out what many Congressmen would have liked to have done themselves'.[25] The fissure became public when Mookerjee explained the reasons for his resignation in Parliament. His speech was 'intermittently cheered by a section of the House', noted a reporter watching the proceedings. But by the time he concluded, he was 'loudly cheered by the *House as a whole* [emphasis added]'.[26] This was a remarkable indicator of wide support for his ideas in a Lok Sabha in which two-thirds of the MPs were from the Congress (364 of 489). The schism within the Congress partially explains why it took over a year for Mookerjee to form the Jan Sangh after he walked out on Nehru. This intense ideological debate and the struggle for power within the party, which very briefly opened up the tantalising possibility of a Congress without Nehru as its leader, formed the subtext to the pre-launch discussions of the Jan Sangh's founders. Mookerjee had been exploring the possibility of founding a party since 1950 through backchannel conversations with the RSS. Yet, as Graham argued, he made no public moves to do so till April 1951. This delay is especially interesting because the first general election was initially planned for mid-1951, not late 1951.[27]

Even as Mookerjee mulled over his options for creating a new Hindu-nationalist political party, Hindu-traditionalist leaders within the Congress launched an offensive against Nehru. The evidence suggests that both Mookerjee and the RSS may have had good reasons to wait for the outcome of this power struggle. Two leading